

In the Cabinet, he is the evangelist in a rush to convert the heathen. For over 46 months now, he has been battling almost every ministry to hand over schemes to panchayats and devolve power to the grassroots without success. This despite the fact that the prime minister had described "Panchayati Raj as the medium to transform rural India into 700 million opportunities". As Railways Minister Lalu Prasad observed in a Cabinet meeting, "Barring railways, Pranab babu (MEA) and Antony bhai (defence), Aiyar has tried to rope in every other ministry into a *bhagidari* (partnership)" with the Panchayati Raj Ministry. Obviously in an era of expanding centralisation, Aiyar's evangelism for devolution has few takers. Some would argue a tactical rather than the bludgeoning approach would have helped. Perhaps, but Aiyar obviously doesn't subscribe to it.

In the age of political correctness and electoral expediency, Aiyar specialises in articulating the unmention-

able. As India sang the rah-rah raga on 9-plus per cent GDP growth, he asked a CII audience if it was not limited to a 0.9 per cent of the one billion populace and, as sports minister, he questioned the hosting of Commonwealth Games and the expenditure on it, only to lose the ministry in the last reshuffle. Some of his colleagues liken Aiyar to the knight tilting at windmills but then that is quintessential Aiyar.

Earlier this year, he announced a national rally of the Panchayati parivar and sent out 2.5 lakh invites. The Finance Ministry and the Planning Commission frowned on the estimated cost of Rs 165 crore and shot down the idea. Not to be thwarted, Aiyar hosted over 8,000 elected representatives and held a national convention which came out with a 15th Anniversary Charter that was released by Prime Minister Manmohan Singh and UPA Chairperson Sonia Gandhi in Delhi last month. The mantra for the convention was appropriately "prad-

han se prapanchayati Raj ke participants tant demand received by power corridor elected state sarpanch fir "We have co

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NUMERICAL STRENGTH of 26 lakh representatives as against 4,8 MLAs and MPs has not helped the children of a lesser democracy.

